

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

1989-08-28

To all National Spiritual Assemblies dear bahá'í

1 in addition to the accompanying letter addressed by the universal house
2 of justice to the followers of bahá'u'lláh concerning the Nineteen day
3 feast, we have been asked to convey its comments on the following points
4 with which you will have to deal in assisting the community in its observance of this
important festival.

5 first, the house of justice is aware that in many areas only a limited time
6 can be devoted to the feast by the friends, because the feast day may come
7 during the week when most people have to work, and the evening hours do not allow
much time for its observance. while the house of justice does

8 not wish to deemphasize the preference expressed by Shoghi effendi that the
9 feast be held on the first day of the bahá'í month, it feels that in instances
10 of difficulty, where the friends would otherwise be unable to attend, the
11 National Spiritual Assembly may point out to local Assemblies that it is
12 permissible to hold the feast at another time within the bahá'í month, such
13 as on a weekend.

14 69-5. cc 1:920.69.12

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71 1986-1992 • The Six Year Plan

72 17Second, the administrative portion of the feast should not be laborious or
73 burdensome. it can become so because too many reports by too many local
74 bahá'í committees are presented at one feast. Such reports could perhaps be
75 conveyed in bulletins. Also, there can be too many messages from agencies
76 of the national administration. while it lies within the discretion of the
77 National Spiritual Assembly to send a message or items of information to

78 be shared at the feast, care must be taken not to overburden these events
 79 with a multiplicity of items from the National Assembly and its auxiliary
 80 agencies. Some National Assemblies have developed the practice of sending a
 message to every feast; this is, of course, not wrong in principle, but they
 81 may need to examine their methods of communicating with the believers and see
 whether occasional messages might not be sufficient. The idea is that the local bahá'í
 communities should exercise control over the feast and
 82 not be made to feel that they are being overrun by messages, instructions and
 assignments from the national administration of the faith. This whole
 83 matter needs to be studied by the National Spiritual Assembly with a balanced
 perspective, so that while important national issues are not ignored,
 84 the potentialities of the feast for development of the local community are
 85 fully realized.

86 Third, the accompanying letter to the friends points to the desirability
 87 of the inclusion in the feast of cultural elements which can enhance the
 88 experience without contravening bahá'í principles. The National Spiritual
 89 Assemblies will want to be watchful that the incorporation of such elements
 90 does not lead to a degeneration of the feast as a uniquely bahá'í institution
 91 and, particularly, that no objectionable customs and practices begin to creep into its
 observance.

92 we have also been asked to send you the enclosed compilation, entitled
 93 The Nineteen Day Feast,
 94 70-1 as a resource on which you can draw in further

educating the community and in answering the questions of the friends

95 concerning this vital institution. you are free to share its contents with the
 96 friends but you are under no obligation to publish it.
 97 with loving bahá'í greetings,

Department of the secretariat

98 70-1. The compilation is too lengthy to include here; see cc 1, pp. 417-58.70.3

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71 message from The Universal House of Justice

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Assessment of Six Year Plan Pioneer Goals

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]